

Creature-Eating Plants

Non-fiction

Most plants make their own food using sunlight, water and air. But some plants live in places where they can't get enough nutrients from the soil, so they have evolved to catch and digest animals – usually insects, but sometimes larger creatures too.

Venus Flytraps

The Venus flytrap is probably the most famous carnivorous plant. It grows in boggy areas of North and South Carolina in the USA. Each of its leaves has two lobes that snap shut when an insect touches the tiny trigger hairs inside. The trap closes in less than a second. Once an insect is trapped, the plant releases digestive juices that break down the creature's soft body over several days. The trap then reopens, ready to catch its next meal. A single trap can catch around three to five insects before it dies and falls off the plant. New traps then grow to replace it.

Pitcher Plants

Pitcher plants lure insects into a deep, tube-shaped trap filled with liquid. The rim of the pitcher is slippery and often scented to attract insects. Once an insect falls in, it is almost impossible for it to climb back out – tiny downward-pointing hairs line the walls of the pitcher, and the insect eventually drowns and is digested.

Some pitcher plants are large enough to trap and digest rats and frogs. Scientists have even found pitcher plants in Borneo that are visited by tree shrews, which perch on the rim to eat the nectar produced by the plant. The droppings left by the shrews fall into the pitcher and provide nutrients – a remarkable partnership.

Sundews

Sundews are covered in sticky, glistening drops that look like dewdrops. These attract insects, which become stuck as soon as they land. The sundew's tentacles then slowly curl around the insect over the course of several hours, bringing more digestive glands into contact with the prey.

Despite being delicate in appearance, sundews are among the most widespread carnivorous plants in the world and can be found on every continent except Antarctica.

Why do they eat animals?

All three plants tend to grow in wet, boggy soil where nitrogen – an essential nutrient – is scarce. By digesting insects and other animals, they obtain the nitrogen they need to survive. This is why you should never feed fertiliser to a carnivorous plant: if they get nitrogen from the soil, they stop producing their traps and may even die.